



All smiles: East Zone secured the Duleep Trophy on the basis of its first-innings lead. PICS: R. RAGU

» TOURNAMENT WRAP

Five days that told a story

East Zone's Duleep Trophy triumph offered more than a title. In Chennai, Ishan Kishan, Tilak Varma and a clutch of younger players provided **glimpses** of Indian cricket's evolving red-ball story.

Aditya Padinjat

aditya.p@thehindu.co.in

In the end, East Zone's wait for its third Duleep Trophy was perhaps slightly anticlimactic.

It came two balls into the 100th over of its second innings with its by-then academic lead standing at 760 runs. Md Kounain Qureshi, batting on 116 not out, patted a C.V. Milind delivery to mid-off; the captains shook hands,

and East Zone won the Duleep Trophy after 14 years on the same ground where it had won its last.

But for all the muted nature of the finish, it was difficult to argue that the result was anything other than richly deserved for an East Zone side that produced a magnificent five days of cricket to shut out the home side.

From white-ball to red-ball

But beyond team titles, the Duleep Trophy 2026 final proved a forum for

questions about the past, present, and future of Indian red-ball cricket to be raised, and in some cases revisited.

None epitomise this quite like the two captains, Ishan Kishan and Tilak Varma. Both have become poster boys of the gung-ho style that won India the T20 World Cup earlier this year, but the Duleep Trophy offered a high-profile opportunity for both to restate their long-form credentials.

Kishan in particular took the